he shifted the focus to give the group a future direction and vision. To achieve this objective, in March 2002, he established the GCC. It comprised all the members of the GEO and two others, J.J. Irani and R.K. Krishna Kumar.

With the GCC functioning as the advisory body of the Tata Group, it met once or twice a fortnight. It became the highest policymaking body and the GEO was made responsible for implementing its directions.

The GCC also 'oversaw the protection and promotion of the Tata brand across geographies and provided advisory services to affiliate companies in several areas'. It directed the 'decision to exit a business or enter a new business through an existing group company along with the board of directors of the concerned company. In addition, [the] GCC initiated a number of corporate-level services that were offered to group companies on a completely discretionary basis'.

In August 2003, Tata Sons inducted Arun Gandhi as a member of the GEO and GCC to serve as the conglomerate's point man on mergers and acquisitions. Later, in January 2004, the Tata Group also hired Alan Rosling as an executive director and a member of the GEO and GCC, to manage the globalization process of the group.

Consumer Satisfaction

One of the key features of the restructuring programme was the emphasis on customer satisfaction. During the Licence Raj, the companies were solely driven by the urge to increase production. According customer satisfaction priority was an exception rather than the rule. As Ratan told the senior management of the group in 1997, only a few companies were motivated by the needs of the customers.

The issue was existential. Tata companies had to break free from their traditional way of thinking that their products and way of doing things were the best. It was important because customer focus gained critical importance in the era of liberalization, which spawned a buyers' market. Speaking during the JRD QV Award function in 1999, Ratan said: 'We have gained the reputation of being a very respectable group but perhaps not truly aligned to a customer's needs, not quick enough to change and therein lies an urgent need for our companies to reorient themselves as they move forward.'